

Chapter 103-2

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The late autumn rain pattered down, blown by the wind to fall lingeringly on the windows. The fine, dense raindrops gathered into streams on the transparent glass, meandering across.

Water droplets condensed on the metal railing, drip-drop, drip-drop, falling straight down from above.

On the distant mountains was a mist that wouldn't disperse. The far horizon was covered by dark, oppressive clouds.

The withered yellow leaves were all shaken from the trees by the wind. The autumn breeze swept the dampened fallen leaves toward some unknown distant place.

The dark gray curtains matched the sky. Faint light refracted through the rain-covered glass windows, falling on the bed.

Unlike sunny weather, where light could make one feel lazy.

The light on gloomy days carried a stifling quality, yet it easily made one want to surrender.

Just wanting to keep falling in this dimness.

Whether below lay an unfathomably deep abyss or a boundless deep sea.

The faint, almost nonexistent light shone into the room. The sounds were scattered into fragments by the wind outside the window. Soft whimpers dispersed into every corner of the room.

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The rain didn't stop until nearly noon.

The clouds parted and the mist dispersed. The cold sun broke through the dark, oppressive cloud layer and scattered down to the world.

The busy traffic on the roads continued as usual. Pedestrians on both banks of the river put away their umbrellas. The river water rose and fell. The city, washed by the light rain, carried the coolness unique to autumn, and even the air became fresh.

Liang Shi pulled open the curtains, and the cold sunlight poured into the room.

Xu Qingzhu was still lying on the bed, eyes half-closed, her fine, soft black hair spread on the pillow. Liang Shi stood backlit, her silhouette slender—a pleasing sight to behold.

Xu Qingzhu pulled her arms back under the covers, wrapping herself up tightly. Only the strawberry marks on her neck couldn't be hidden.

She reached up to press the tingling spot on her neck, the corners of her lips slightly raised.

This day didn't seem so gloomy after all.

At least one's mood was exceptionally good.

Xu Qingzhu's cool voice rang out in the room. "Liang Shi."

When she called Liang Shi's name, the ending tone rose upward, carrying a hint of joy and pleasure, even though the syllable "Shi" was more suited to going down.

But she insisted on raising it.

Liang Shi turned around. Her long hair was casually tied up in a loose ponytail, resting on her back.

She had already changed into a different set of nightclothes. The previous set had been thrown into the dirty laundry basket in Xu Qingzhu's room, piled together with Xu Qingzhu's clothes.

Along with Xu Qingzhu's clothes, all piled together, to be thrown into the washing machine later.

Both of them seemed to have slight cleanliness tendencies, but when it came to each other, it wasn't that serious.

Liang Shi could share Xu Qingzhu's things, and had even bitten into food that Xu Qingzhu had half-eaten.

Perhaps after intimate contact, one would include the other person within one's acceptable range.

So clothes could also be washed in the same washing machine.

One person didn't have that many clothes to wash, but with two people's clothes together, it was just the right amount for one load.

Initially, Liang Shi had suggested this to conserve water, and Xu Qingzhu had no objections.

Hearing Xu Qingzhu call her, Liang Shi turned around and responded with an "mm," then sat down on the bay window, shaking her arms. Like playing piano, her fingers curled and uncurled in the air.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and asked in a low voice, "Tired?"

Liang Shi: "....."

After sitting on the bay window, her long legs had nowhere to go and just rested casually on the floor.

After hearing Xu Qingzhu ask this, Liang Shi immediately withdrew her hands, resting them on the bay window to support herself. She smiled. "What's there to be tired about?"

"I'm tired." Xu Qingzhu said, her voice very soft. But there was no more rain outside, only the sound of water flowing through the pipes past the window, not quite audible, so it wouldn't drown out Xu Qingzhu's voice.

With the light now present, Liang Shi felt slightly unnatural. She didn't look directly at her face, and even the tips of her ears were a bit red.

Almost without hesitation, Liang Shi subconsciously asked, "Where are you tired?"

Xu Qingzhu: ".....Everywhere."

Liang Shi: "....."

Awkwardness spread instantly. Yet after her mind went blank, Liang Shi asked, "Want me to give you a massage?"

Xu Qingzhu buried half her head in the covers and laughed softly. "No need."

Liang Shi's expression was somewhat wooden, even a bit dazed. Two seconds later, she lowered her head and smiled helplessly. "Xu Qingzhu....."

Having been silent for so long without saying long sentences, her throat felt a bit uncomfortable when she spoke. She rubbed her throat, which still seemed to retain a damp, warm sensation from being sucked and bitten.

Bullied to the point of not knowing what to do.

There was no other way but to indulge her.

Including finding all her behaviors amusing.

She had bitten someone, yet still liked to ask in a hoarse voice, "Does it feel good? Do you like it?"

When Liang Shi didn't respond, she would continue calling, "Teacher Liang?"

Calling until the person was at a loss, not knowing whether to answer or not.

Although Liang Shi was a few years older than her, she wasn't as bold.

Growing in age but not in courage.

To be precise, Liang Shi didn't dare and couldn't let go.

But Xu Qingzhu insisted on keeping herself physically and mentally pleased, bravely saying no to things she didn't like. So she was bold, because she preferred to make herself happy.

Yet she also didn't forget about Liang Shi.

Liang Shi didn't answer and kept silent, but her throat felt like it was going through tribulation.

When she got up, she used her phone's front camera to check. The deadly angle made her neck look like she had gone through a tropical jungle, bitten all over by giant mosquitoes.¹

Even though it had already ended quite a while ago, Liang Shi's voice was still a bit uncomfortable when speaking. She said to her, "Stop teasing me."

Xu Qingzhu obediently closed her eyes and pretended to sleep, letting the cold sun after the rain shine on her face. Her fair skin was delicate as if it could be broken by a breath, still carrying a rosy flush, like a thin layer of blush had been applied to her cheeks.

Liang Shi watched her for a while, unconsciously spacing out for a moment, before finally standing up and asking what she wanted to eat.

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1. This is a humorous euphemism. "Strawberry marks" (草莓印) and the comparison to "mosquito bites" are both common Chinese slang terms for hickeys/love bites. ⇐